

QUEEN OF THE MAHANADI

Rashmita Sahu's Rise in Indian Canoeing

The Mahanadi River, often described as the lifeline of Odisha, has long been a source of sustenance, culture, and inspiration. Among the countless stories it carries, one stands out of a young girl whose bond with the river transformed her life. That girl, Rashmita Sahu from district Cuttack, is today Odisha's "boat queen" a canoeist whose journey from hardship to national recognition is as inspiring as it is remarkable.

At just 20, Rashmita has already been recognised by none other than Prime Minister Narendra Modi, during his Mann Ki Baat broadcast who lauded her achievements and even spoke to her personally. He praised her two gold medals at the Khelo India Aquatics Festival in Srinagar and said her journey would inspire the youth of India.

Rashmita lost both parents before her teenage years. Her father was left bedridden after an accident when she was nine, and four years later her mother passed away in another accident. Orphaned young, she turned to the Mahanadi for solace, where paddling became both an escape and an anchor.

Her potential was spotted in 2017 during a Sports Authority of India (SAI) selection camp at Jagatpur. Coaches were struck by her strength and determination, inducting her into the Aquatics Centre of Excellence. Since then, she has built an impressive record, collecting more than 30 national medals. Highlights of her journey include a silver and bronze at the National Games 2024 in Uttarakhand, a gold at the National Canoeing Championship in Bhopal, and a stunning double gold at the Khelo India



Aquatics Festival 2025 in Srinagar, where she clocked 53.53 seconds in the 200m sprint. Her discipline also earned her a post as a constable in the Odisha Police in 2024, adding stability to her sporting life. The next big target is the 2026 Asian Games. Rashmita dreams of carrying the tricolour to the podium, and her coach Laishram Johnson Singh believes she has the potential to be a genuine medal contender. Odisha's increasing investment in water sports through the SAI Centre at Jagatpur and the Kayaking and Canoeing Association of Odisha has given her the platform to thrive. Rashmita's story is not just about sporting success.

It is about resilience, the ability to turn grief into grit. From losing her parents at a tender age to earning praise from the Prime Minister, she has shown that even the strongest currents can be conquered. Today, the Mahanadi's daughter stands as a beacon for India's youth, proving that courage, perseverance, and belief can chart a course to glory.